

Religious Experience: Nature and Object

Philosophy Optional · Paper II · Philosophy of Religion

COMPLETE MULTI-PAGE FLOWCHART COMPANION

Translation-audited edition: every Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit or Hindi technical term carries an immediate English meaning at first use in every visual box.

Regenerated 2026-08-21 · Landscape continuation format

MASTER LEARNING SEQUENCE

1. Separate phenomenology, object and warrant
2. Explain James's marks and pragmatic fruits
3. Explain Otto's numinous and the Holy
4. Compare Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) and Radhakrishnan
5. Distinguish sacred, holy and God as object
6. Test veridicality, testimony and diversity
7. Distinguish prayer from worship
8. Convert private experience into public discourse
9. Compare perceptual and constructivist models
10. Build 10/15/20-mark answers

TRANSLATION AND DEFINITION RULE

Every visual box is independently readable: its first Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit or Hindi technical term is followed immediately by an exam-safe English meaning. Long definitions wrap and continue; no fixed line limit is used.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

[FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data. [INFERENCE] identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement.

Source corpus	Final location	Retention decision
Canonical owner §§0–7	Basic Learning Session	Complete phenomenology, Indian accounts, object/warrant grid, parity bench and answer skeletons retained
Canonical owner §§9–19	Optional Advanced	Complete James, Otto, Advaita (non-dual Vedānta), Radhakrishnan, typology, prayer/worship, public discourse, Alston, debates and answer control retained
Audited PYQ ledger	PYQs and Answer Practice	All eight owner questions, one from each year 2018–2025, retained with exact wording and new full solutions
Premium diagnostic set	MCQs / Remediation	Forty core and eight remedial questions retained with strict answer rotation
Original practice	PYQs and Answer Practice	Six non-PYQ solved models retained
Advanced dossier	Optional Advanced	Perceptual model, constructivism, diversity, neural mediation and non-dual/intentional contrasts reconciled
Consolidated register	Final section	A–L retrieval framework retains complete answer logic

Visible learning labels. James, Otto, Advaita (non-dual Vedānta), Radhakrishnan, sacred/holy, prayer/worship, public discourse and veridicality are CORE PAPER II. Phenomenology–object–warrant separation, comparison and graded verdict are CORE ANSWER. Neuroscience and bounded interdisciplinary links are SUPPORTING. Perceptual models, constructivism, perennialism and specialist diversity disputes are OPTIONAL ADVANCED.

What not to over-study. Do not fill answers with brain-region catalogues, mystical case lists or claims that ineffability makes experience unintelligible. Master the phenomenological marks, claimed object, warrant test, strongest critique and one Indian comparison.

Learning roadmap

Unit	Learner objective
1	Separate phenomenology, object and warrant
2	Explain James's marks and pragmatic fruits
3	Explain Otto's numinous and the Holy
4	Compare Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) and Radhakrishnan
5	Distinguish sacred, holy and God as object
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Current scholarly anchor — [SUPPORTING]

[FACT] Fact: A 2025 Frontiers in Neuroscience review described neuroscience of religion as the study of correlations between brain functions and religious practices, beliefs and experiences, while emphasizing methodological and definitional limitations.
[CAUTION] Inference: Neural mediation does not by itself prove either veridicality or illusion. It explains a mechanism or correlate; the philosophical question of the experience's object and warrant remains open.

Visual gateway — ask three questions in order

1. PHENOMENOLOGY: What is the experience like?
- |
2. OBJECT: What, if anything, is encountered?
- |
3. WARRANT: What reason is there to treat it as veridical?

James mainly describes phenomenology and fruits.
Otto analyses the numinous object-pole.
Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) revises the subject-object structure itself.
Alston and Swinburne address epistemic entitlement.

Master rule: A vivid or transformative experience can be psychologically real without its interpretation being automatically true. Equally, conceptual or neural mediation does not automatically make it fabricated.

0. ONE-SCREEN MAP [CAUTION]

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE
NATURE (what it is like) OBJECT (what it is of)

James: PRIMARY marks — the "MORE", the divine/sacred, ineffability + noetic quality Brahman (ultimate reality), God, the numinous
James: USUAL marks — |
transiency + passivity WESTERN: personal God (theistic mysticism)
Otto: the NUMINOUS — INDIAN: Brahman/ātman (ultimate reality and the true self) (Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) — non-dual, mysterium tremendum et identity experience; anubhava (direct experience or realisation))
fascinans Radhakrishnan: intuitive, self-certifying
Stace: extrovertive / introvertive realisation of the Spirit
Zaehner: nature / monistic / theistic ("The Hindu View of Life")
Alston: perceptual model (M-perception)
|
is it VERIDICAL (of a real object) or merely psychological?
generic OBJECT-category: the SACRED / HOLY (Durkheim, Otto, Eliade) — §9.6

[MEMORY] Mnemonic — James's marks are two-plus-two, not four. I-N = Ineffable + Noetic are the defining marks ("entitle any state to be called mystical"); T-P = Transient + Passive are the usual accompaniments, "less sharply marked". Writing all four as equal is the standard error. Otto's object = the numinous (tremendum + fascinans). Indian object = Brahman (ultimate reality) (non-dual).

1. NATURE — Western accounts [FACT]

William James (2022 PYQ) — the marks of mystical states, correctly graded: [FACT] In the Varieties*, James distinguishes two marks that are jointly sufficient to entitle a state to be called mystical from two further marks that are less sharply defined but usually found. Reproduce this grading; do not present a flat list of four.
* PRIMARY / DEFINING (the two that settle the classification):
1. Ineffability — the state defies adequate expression; its quality must be directly experienced, and, like a feeling rather than a proposition, it cannot be imparted to those who have not had it. James calls this the "handiest" mark.
2. Noetic quality — mystical states present themselves as states of knowledge: "states of insight into depths of truth unplumbed by the discursive intellect", carrying a curious sense of authority.
* USUAL / ACCOMPANYING (present in most cases, but not definitional):
3. Transiency — the state cannot be sustained for long; James notes its characteristic brevity, though it may recur and develop.
4. Passivity — although the onset can be facilitated by preliminary voluntary operations, once the state sets in the mystic feels grasped and held by a superior power.
[CAUTION] Why the grading matters in an exam: it is what lets you say that a state may be genuinely mystical without being brief or wholly passive — which is exactly the situation of Indian jñāna (liberating knowledge)*, a stable, established realisation rather than an episode. A flat four-mark list makes Advaitic realisation look like a failed mystical state.
* James's method and framework: he is empirical and pragmatic — he studies first-person documents, refuses "medical materialism" (the fallacy of discrediting a state by its physiological or pathological origin), and evaluates religion by its fruits, invoking the biblical maxim "by their fruits ye shall know them" (Matthew 7:16/20) as a criterion rather than coining it. [CAUTION] He also holds mystical states to be authoritative for the one who has them, but to impose no authority on outsiders — a limitation that must be stated, since it is the hinge of the veridicality question. Religion for James is personal before institutional; the experience of the "MORE" connects the self, through the subconscious, to a wider reality.
* Varieties covered: healthy-mindedness and the sick soul; the divided self and conversion; saintliness; mysticism.
Rudolf Otto — the numinous: the object of religious experience is the "Holy" / numinous, experienced as mysterium tremendum et fascinans (mystery that evokes dread and attraction) — an a priori, non-rational awe: overwhelming (tremendum), yet fascinating/attracting (fascinans*), wholly other. [FACT]
* Schleiermacher: religion's essence = the "feeling of absolute dependence." [CAUTION]
* W. T. Stace and R. C. Zaehner classify the material into rival typologies — §9.6; William Alston models it on perception — §9.8.

2. NATURE — Indian accounts [FACT]

* Anubhava (direct experience or realisation) (direct realisation): in Indian thought the highest religious experience is immediate, intuitive realisation (anubhava/aparokṣānubhūti (immediate non-mediated realisation)), not mere belief — the goal of the whole spiritual path. [FACT]
* Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) (2024 PYQ) — features: [FACT]
Non-dual (nirvikalpa (non-conceptual and non-dual)) experience — the collapse of subject–object duality; the realiser is Brahman (ultimate reality) ("aham brahmāsmi (I am Brahman)").
* **Self-certifying (svataḥ-siddha (self-established or self-certifying))**, beyond objectifying speech (avācya (inexpressible by objectifying speech); yato vāco nivartante (that from which words return)), bliss (ānanda (bliss)), beyond the categories of ordinary cognition. [CAUTION] Terminological discipline: do not call this experience anirvacanīya (indeterminable as either real or unreal). In Advaita's technical vocabulary anirvacanīya is the status of māyā (cosmic appearance) and the world-appearance (sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa (different from both the real and the unreal)), not of Brahman or of the realisation of Brahman — see Religious Language §9.5 and Notions of God §2. Spell it anirvacanīya throughout.
Not a relation* to an object but identity — distinguishing it from theistic (dualistic) mysticism.
* **Radhakrishnan (2025 PYQ — The Hindu View of Life): religion is grounded in direct, intuitive spiritual experience** of the Real (anubhava), which is self-certifying and universal across traditions; dogma/ritual are secondary interpretations of this core experience. Religious experience is integral intuition — a knowing that unites, higher than sense & reason. [FACT]

3. OBJECT & the question of VERIDICALITY [CAUTION]

* The object: theistic traditions -> a personal God; Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) -> Brahman/ātman (ultimate reality and the true self) (non-dual); Otto -> the numinous/Holy; Buddhism -> nirvāṇa (extinguishing of craving and suffering) (no personal deity).
* Is religious experience veridical (of a real object) or merely subjective/psychological? [CAUTION]
For veridicality:* Principle of Credulity (Swinburne) — if it seems to one that X is present, probably X is, absent defeaters; the noetic quality; convergence of mystics.
Against:* naturalistic explanations (Freud — projection/wish-fulfilment; Marx — opium; neuroscience); diversity of experiences across religions (which object is real?).
* Hick's pluralist reply: the various experiences are culturally-shaped responses to one ultimate "Real" ("the Real an sich" experienced through different lenses). [FACT]
* Mystical experience & revelation (2023 PYQ): mystical experience can be a vehicle of revelation (God/the Real disclosed experientially) — non-propositional revelation; the two are intimately linked. [CAUTION]

4. COMPARISON GRID [CAUTION]

Thinker	Nature	Object	Key term
James	defining: ineffable + noetic; usual: transient + passive	the "MORE"	varieties; fruits; medical materialism rejected
Otto	non-rational awe	the numinous/Holy	mysterium tremendum et fascinans (mystery that evokes dread and attraction)
Schleiermacher	feeling of dependence	the Infinite	absolute dependence
Stace	extrovertive (unity through the senses) / introvertive (contentless unitary consciousness)	the One	common-core thesis
Zaehner	nature / monistic / theistic mysticism	Nature, the isolated soul, or a personal God	pan-en-henic (all-in-one nature mysticism); typology with a ranking
Alston	perception-like, with an appearing object	God as directly presented	M-perception; doxastic practice
Advaita (non-dual Vedānta)	non-dual, self-certifying bliss	Brahman (ultimate reality) (=ātman (true self))	nirvikalpa (non-conceptual and non-dual); aham brahmāsmi (I am Brahman)
Radhakrishnan	integral intuition (anubhava (direct experience or realisation))	the Spirit/Real	self-certifying experience
Durkheim/Eliade	socially and spatially structured	the sacred (vs the profane)	hierophany; axis mundi (symbolic centre linking cosmic levels)

5. FOUNDATIONAL STATEMENT BANK [CAUTION]

- 1. [FACT] James treats the noetic mark as an experienced disclosure of insight not reached by discursive reasoning alone.
- 2. [FACT] James's pragmatic method tests religious life by enduring fruits rather than dismissing it through causal origins.
- 3. [FACT] Otto names the Holy's distinctive phenomenology mysterium tremendum et fascinans (mystery that evokes dread and attraction).
- 4. [FACT] Aham brahmāsmi (I am Brahman) is an Upaniṣadic identity formula central to Advaitic interpretation.
- 5. [CAUTION] Radhakrishnan gives direct spiritual intuition priority over its later doctrinal and institutional expressions.

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6. APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS [CAUTION]

- 1. [James] "Nature & variety of religious experience per William James." (2022) -> §1.
- 2. [Advaita (non-dual Vedānta)] "Main features of religious experience in Advaita Vedānta (school grounded in the concluding teaching of the Vedas)." (2024) -> §2.
- 3. [Radhakrishnan] "Nature & object of religious experience per Radhakrishnan." (2025) -> §2.
- 4. [Mystical-revelation] "Relation between mystical experience & revelation." (2023) -> §3.
- 5. [Veridicality] "Is religious experience a reliable ground for belief in God?" -> §3 + §9.9.
- 6. [Sacred/Holy] "'Sacred' and 'Holy' as generic names for the object of religion — can God be the object?" (2018, 20m) -> §9.10.
- 7. [Public discourse] "How far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse?" (2019, 15m) -> §9.8.
- 8. [Prayer/worship] "Distinguish prayer and worship and determine their place in religion." (2020, 15m) -> §9.7 — two deliverables, both required.
- 9. [Vedāntic] "Religious experience in the light of the Vedāntic tradition." (2021, 15m) -> §2 + §9.3.
- 10. [Typology] "Is mystical experience one thing or many?" -> §9.6 — Stace vs Zaehner vs Katz.

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6A. INDIAN–WESTERN PARITY BENCH [CAUTION]

Axis	Western	Indian	Discriminating point
Structure of the experience	Encounter/union with an Other (Otto, theistic mysticism)	Identity-recognition (Advaita (non-dual Vedānta)) or isolation (Sāṃkhya-Yoga (enumerative dualism and its discipline of practice))	Relation vs identity is a logical, not merely stylistic, difference
Duration	Transient (James's usual mark)	Jñāna (liberating knowledge) is stable and established, not episodic	Why James's grading of marks matters
Method	Grace, contemplation, sacrament	Disciplined, staged, repeatable (aṣṭāṅga (eight-limbed discipline), śravaṇa—manana—nididhyāsana (hearing scripture, reflective reasoning and deep contemplation))	India's replicability claim in the public-discourse question
Authority	Authoritative for the subject only (James)	Svataḥ-siddha (self-established or self-certifying) — self-certifying, but tested by guru and śruti (revealed Vedic scripture)	Both restrict transferability; India adds institutional discernment
Object-term	God, the Holy, the numinous	Brahman (ultimate reality), puruṣa (pure consciousness), nirvāṇa (extinguishing of craving and suffering), the Tīrthaṅkara (Jain ford-maker and liberated teacher)	Generic term must be "sacred", not "God"
Ritual correlate	Prayer, sacrament, liturgy	Upāsanā (meditative worship), pūjā (ritual worship), japa (repetitive sacred recitation), dhyāna (meditation)	Jain/Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school) worship without a responsive deity

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7. PYQ-MAPPED MODEL-ANSWER SKELETONS [CAUTION]

7.1 — "Nature and variety of religious experience as presented by William James." (2022, 15m)

Intro : James — empirical, pragmatic study of personal religion (Varieties).
Body : 4 marks — ineffable, noetic, transient, passive; the "MORE"; test by fruits; varieties (healthy-minded vs sick-souled; conversion; mysticism).
Assess: strength — takes experience seriously, empirical; limit — subjectivism, veridicality unproven.
Concl : religious experience is the living root of religion, though its object needs further warrant.

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7.2 — "Main features of religious experience according to Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) Vedānta (school grounded in the concluding teaching of the Vedas)." (2024, 15m)

Intro : Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) — highest experience is aparokṣānubhūti (immediate non-mediated realisation) (direct realisation of Brahman (ultimate reality)).
Body : non-dual (nirvikalpa (non-conceptual and non-dual)), subject-object collapse, identity (aham brahmāsmi (I am Brahman)), self-certifying (svataḥ-siddha (self-established or self-certifying)), beyond objectifying speech (avācya (inexpressible by objectifying speech); yato vāco nivartante (that from which words return)), bliss (ānanda (bliss)). [Do NOT write anirvacanīya (indeterminable as either real or unreal) here — that term belongs to māyā (cosmic appearance).]
Contrast: vs theistic/dualistic mysticism (relation to a personal God) & James's "MORE".
Concl : the object is not encountered but realised as one's own Self.

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7.3 — "Distinguish between prayer and worship and determine their place in religioin." (2020, 15m)

Intro : two deliverables — the distinction, then the placement. Do both.
Distinction: prayer = ADDRESS (communication); worship = ASCRIPTION OF SUPREME WORTH (homage).
Axes: essential act | direction | form (spontaneous vs ritual) | locus (private vs corporate) | presupposition (a responsive God vs a supremely valuable reality).
Kinds of prayer: adoration, confession, thanksgiving, supplication (ACTS); contemplative/wordless prayer as the limit case where address becomes silence.
Problems: petitionary prayer — if God is omniscient, good and immutable, petition is idle.
Aquinas: we pray to obtain what God has ordained shall be obtained THROUGH prayer.
Stump: petition protects the friendship-structure against overwhelming benefaction.
Worship — Rachels' moral-autonomy argument; replies (worth ≠ blind obedience).
Indian: prārthanā (prayer), stuti (praise), japa (repetitive sacred recitation), dhyāna (meditation), upāsanā (meditative worship), pūjā/arcana (ritual worship and offering), vandana (reverential salutation), ātma-nivedana (self-surrender).
Decisive cases: Jain vītarāga (one free from passions) cannot respond -> worship without answered petition;
Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school)'s apūrva (unseen potency produced by ritual action) -> ritual efficacy without a granting deity;
Advaita (non-dual Vedānta)'s upāsanā -> efficacious at vyāvahārika (empirical conventional level), transcended at pāramārthika (ultimate level of reality);
Buddhist pūjā (ritual worship) as commemorative/dispositional.
Placement: prayer is religion's RELATIONAL organ; worship its EVALUATIVE and COMMUNAL organ.
Concl : a religion can survive the loss of petition; none survives the loss of worship — because nothing would then mark the ultimate as ultimate.

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7.4 — "How far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse?" (2019. 15m)

Intro : the stem asks HOW FAR — so the answer must be graded, not yes/no.
Against: ineffability; privileged access; James's own limit (authoritative only for the subject); no shared checking procedure; private-language worries; Rawlsian public reason.
For : six intersubjective criteria — (1) phenomenological description (James, Otto, Stace, Zaehner built public typologies from private reports); (2) coherence; (3) traditional discernment norms (Teresa's criteria; the guru's verification); (4) moral fruits, which are observable; (5) replicability through disciplined practice (yoga (disciplined path of spiritual integration), nididhyāsana (deep contemplative assimilation) — Vivekananda's and Radhakrishnan's "experimental" claim, reported as a claim); (6) Alston's doxastic practices.
Bridge: Habermas — full expression in the informal public sphere, with a translation proviso before formal state decision-making.
Crit : these criteria test AUTHENTICITY, not TRUTH — concede this explicitly.
Concl : publicly discussable as data, description and practice; privately probative as evidence.

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7.5 — "'Sacred' and 'Holy' as generic names for the object of religion. Can one have God as the object?" (2018, 20m)

Intro : the stem grants the generic category and asks after the specific one — answer in degrees.
B1 : why 'sacred/holy' became generic — Otto (the holy as a non-moral, non-rational quality disclosed in numinous awe); Durkheim (the sacred defined relationally against the profane, with no deity required); Eliade (hierophany structuring sacred space and time); and the decisive reason — non-theistic religions have a sacred but no God (nirvāṇa (extinguishing of craving and suffering)/Dharma, Tīrthaṅkara (Jain ford-maker and liberated teacher)/siddha (perfected liberated being), the apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin) Veda).
B2 : can God be the object? YES for theistic traditions, where God is not one sacred item but the SOURCE and MEASURE of holiness; NO as a generic definition, since it stipulates Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school) out of religion.
B3 : the discriminating point — Otto's holy (phenomenological quality) is not Durkheim's sacred (social classification); treating them as one word misses the objection to each.
Indian: pavitra (holy or ritually pure)/śuddha (pure), maṅgala (auspiciousness), puṇya (meritorious or sacred), tīrtha (pilgrimage crossing-place), kṣetra (sacred field or place); sacred time in the ritual calendar; the Veda's sanctity without a sanctifier. Purity/auspiciousness, not dread, often organises the Indian sacred — a real limit on Otto's universality.
Crit : over-breadth (flags, nations); reply — add the soteriological requirement.
Concl : 'sacred' is the genus; God is theism's paradigm species of it.

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PYQ ROUTING CHECKPOINT

PYQ 1 — 2018, Q7(a), 20 marks

PYQ 2 — 2019, Q7(c), 15 marks

PYQ 3 — 2020, Q7(b), 15 marks

PYQ 4 — 2021, Q7(c), 15 marks

PYQ 5 — 2022, Q7(c), 15 marks

PYQ 6 — 2023, Q8(c), 15 marks

PYQ 7 — 2024, Q8(c), 15 marks

PYQ 8 — 2025, Q8(a), 20 marks

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH — NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

The dossier adds four bounded contrasts: perceptual model versus constructivism; perennial experiential core versus hard diversity; neural reduction versus non-reductive embodiment; and Advaitic non-dual awareness versus theistic intentional encounter. Use one contrast to sharpen evaluation, never as a substitute for James, Otto, Radhakrishnan or the exact PYQ demand.

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9. ADVANCED DOCTRINE DOSSIERs

9.1 William James

* Doctrine statement. [FACT] Mystical states are marked by ineffability and noetic quality, with transiency and passivity as usual additional marks; their authority is strongest for the subject and tested pragmatically by fruits.
* Argument. [FACT] James gathers first-person reports, identifies recurrent phenomenological features, and refuses to reduce their value to pathological origins because causal origin does not by itself settle truth or worth.
* Presupposition. [CAUTION] First-person testimony is legitimate data and pragmatic transformation is evidentially relevant.
* Distinction. [FACT] Noetic quality means experienced insight, not independently demonstrated knowledge.
* Canonical example. [FACT] Conversion reorganises a divided self and is assessed through enduring moral integration.
* Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Private certainty cannot establish a public object. James restricts coercive authority: the experience may rationally authorise the experiencer without binding outsiders.

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9.2 Otto's numinous

Doctrine statement. [FACT] The numinous is a non-rational awareness of the holy as mysterium tremendum et fascinans (mystery that evokes dread and attraction)*: mysterious, overwhelming and attracting.
* Argument. [FACT] Ordinary moral predicates do not exhaust holiness; religious awe displays a distinctive quality disclosed in experience and later schematised by rational and ethical concepts.
* Presupposition. [CAUTION] The phenomenological distinctiveness of awe supports a distinctive object rather than a merely unusual emotion.
* Distinction. [FACT] Non-rational does not mean irrational; it means not reducible to conceptual-moral judgement.
* Canonical example. [FACT] Creature-feeling before the "wholly other" combines dread, humility and fascination.
* Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Psychology can explain awe without a numinous object. Otto's phenomenological reply describes intentional structure, but description alone does not prove veridicality.

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9.3 Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) aparokṣānubhūti (immediate non-mediated realisation)

* Doctrine statement. [FACT] Liberating experience is immediate recognition of non-dual self-luminous consciousness, not sensory encounter with Brahman (ultimate reality) as an external object.
Argument. [FACT] Subject–object cognition presupposes witnessing consciousness; śruti (revealed Vedic scripture)* removes false identification; disciplined inquiry culminates in recognition that ātman (true self) is Brahman.
* Presupposition. [CAUTION] Consciousness is self-revealing and non-objectifiable; non-dual testimony can remove ignorance.
Distinction. [FACT] It is not a temporary altered state alone; stable knowledge (jñāna (liberating knowledge)*) matters more than episodic ecstasy.
* Canonical example. [FACT] The tenth-man story: instruction does not create the missing person but removes ignorance of an already present fact.
* Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] A contentless experience cannot identify Brahman. Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) replies that Brahman is self, not inferred object; conceptual instruction prepares a non-objective recognition.

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9.4 Radhakrishnan's integral intuition

* Doctrine statement. [FACT] Religion originates in direct integral apprehension of spiritual reality; creeds and institutions are secondary conceptual expressions.
* Argument. [FACT] Discursive reason divides subject and object; religious intuition integrates cognition, feeling and will; cross-traditional spiritual transformation indicates a common experiential depth.
* Presupposition. [CAUTION] Intuition can disclose reality rather than merely report subjective intensity.
* Distinction. [FACT] Radhakrishnan's "intuition" is not a hunch; it is claimed as disciplined, integral and transformative awareness.
* Canonical example. [FACT] Diverse doctrinal formulations can be treated as interpretations of a common realised depth.
* Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] The account may privilege Advaitic unity and assimilate theistic difference. Reply: universality concerns experiential depth, not identical doctrinal description; the adequacy of that reply remains contested.

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9.5 Veridicality, testimony and plural experience

* Doctrine statement. [CAUTION] Religious experience supplies prima facie but defeasible warrant when phenomenology, subject reliability, coherence and fruits survive defeaters.
* Argument. [FACT] Swinburne's principle of credulity treats apparent experience as probably veridical absent special reasons for doubt; testimony extends warrant to hearers.
* Presupposition. [CAUTION] Perceptual and religious seemings are sufficiently analogous.
* Distinction. [FACT] Explaining neural correlation does not by itself explain away the putative object; causal explanation and epistemic defeat are separate.
* Canonical example. [FACT] Conflicting reports of personal God, non-dual Brahman (ultimate reality) and emptiness generate a cross-tradition defeater problem.
* Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Diversity suggests construction rather than common reality. Hick proposes culturally mediated responses to the Real; critics argue the unknowable Real cannot ground determinate claims.

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9.6 Typologies of mysticism: Stace and Zaehner

* Why typology matters. [CAUTION] "Is religious experience one thing described differently, or several different things?" is the question on which pluralism, veridicality and the common-core debate all turn. Two classifications dominate, and they give opposite answers. W. T. Stace (Mysticism and Philosophy*, 1960) — a two-fold classification with a common core. [FACT] Extrovertive mysticism: the unifying vision is achieved through* the physical senses. The mystic still sees the multiplicity of objects but perceives the One shining through them, with an apprehension of an inner subjectivity or life in all things. * Introvertive mysticism: all sensory and conceptual content is excluded, leaving a unitary, contentless pure consciousness — non-spatial, non-temporal. Stace regards this as the higher and more complete type. * Shared characteristics of both: a sense of objectivity or reality; blessedness/peace; a feeling of the holy or sacred; paradoxicality; and ineffability. * Stace's decisive methodological move: he distinguishes the experience itself from its interpretation, and argues that the experiences converge cross-culturally while the interpretations (theistic, monistic, Buddhist) diverge. This is the classic perennialist / common-core thesis. R. C. Zaehner (Mysticism Sacred and Profane*, 1957) — a three-fold classification that denies a common core. [FACT] 1. **Nature mysticism (pan-en-henic (all-in-one nature mysticism), "all-in-one"): a sense of oneness with nature; Zaehner controversially groups certain drug-induced states here, in explicit opposition to Aldous Huxley's claims for mescaline. 2. Monistic mysticism:** the isolation or identity of the soul with an impersonal absolute — Sāṃkhya-Yoga (enumerative dualism and its discipline of practice)'s kaivalya (isolation of pure consciousness), Advaita (non-dual Vedānta)'s non-dual realisation. 3. Theistic mysticism: loving union with a personal God in which the distinction between creature and creator is preserved — Rāmānuja, Sufism, Christian mysticism. [CAUTION] Zaehner ranks these, treating theistic mysticism as the highest and most complete. This ranking is widely criticised as confessionally motivated (he was a Catholic convert), and the criticism should be stated — but so should the genuine philosophical point behind it: monistic and theistic reports differ in their logical form* (identity vs relation), and a common-core theory has to explain that away rather than assume it. The Katz–Forman dispute (the modern continuation). [FACT] Steven Katz ("Language, Epistemology and Mysticism", 1978) argues constructivism: there are no unmediated experiences; the mystic's tradition, expectations, concepts and practices shape the experience itself, so a Jewish mystic does not have a Buddhist experience differently described — they have different experiences. [FACT] Robert Forman replies with the Pure Consciousness Event (PCE): a contentless state, by definition, has nothing for concepts to shape, so Katz's thesis fails precisely at the introvertive limit. [CAUTION] Verdict: constructivism is very strong for extrovertive and theistic reports and weakest for the contentless* case, which is exactly where its opponents concentrate. Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Objection to Stace: "interpretation" is doing all the work — if you subtract enough interpretation from any two experiences you can always make them look alike. Reply: the shared phenomenological marks (objectivity, blessedness, paradoxicality, ineffability) are reported within the descriptions, not imposed after them. [CAUTION] Objection to Zaehner: the typology smuggles in a theological ranking. Reply: the classification can be retained while the ranking* is dropped — and it usually should be. * Verdict formula. [CAUTION] "Stace's two-fold scheme buys cross-cultural unity by relegating difference to interpretation; Zaehner's three-fold scheme preserves difference at the price of a contested hierarchy. The defensible position keeps Stace's extrovertive/introvertive distinction, keeps Zaehner's monistic/theistic distinction, and drops Zaehner's ranking."

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9.7 Prayer and worship: the distinction and their place in religion (2020 Q7(b) owner-module)

The distinction. [CAUTION] Prayer is address — communicative directedness toward the divine, which may be petition, intercession, thanksgiving, confession, adoration or wordless contemplation. Worship is acknowledgement of worth* — the ascription of supreme value to the sacred, characteristically ritual, embodied, communal and regulated. Prayer can be silent, solitary and spontaneous; worship is typically enacted, corporate and liturgically ordered. Adoration is the overlap: it is both prayer (address) and worship (ascription of worth).

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Axis	Prayer	Worship
Essential act	Address / communication	Ascription of supreme worth (homage)
Direction	Person-to-person (I–Thou)	Creature-before-the-holy
Form	Verbal or silent; may be spontaneous	Ritual, embodied, rule-governed
Locus	Often private	Characteristically corporate
Presupposes	A God who can hear and respond	A reality of supreme value; response is not required
Non-theistic availability	[CAUTION] Strained	[FACT] Available (see below)

* [FACT] The classical Western scheme of prayer is often summarised as A-C-T-S: Adoration, Confession, Thanksgiving, Supplication — a convenient enumeration for the "kinds of prayer" part of the stem. * The philosophical problem of petitionary prayer. [FACT] (1) If God is omniscient, he already knows the need. (2) If God is perfectly good, he will already do whatever is best. (3) If God is immutable, prayer cannot change him. (4) Therefore petition is either pointless or an attempt to manipulate perfection. * Aquinas' reply: we pray not in order to change the divine disposition but so that we may obtain what God has determined shall be obtained through prayer — prayer is written into the causal order as a genuine secondary cause, not as an override of the primary one. * [FACT] Eleonore Stump ("Petitionary Prayer", 1979): the value of petition lies in protecting the relationship — unrequested benefaction from an overwhelmingly superior being risks spoiling or overwhelming the recipient; asking preserves the friendship-structure within which the giving is good

for the recipient. [CAUTION] Residual difficulty: this justifies petition's value*, not the claim that outcomes causally depend on it. The philosophical problem of worship. [FACT] James Rachels, "God and Human Autonomy" (1971), argues that (1) worship entails unqualified, unconditional obedience; (2) moral agency requires that one never abdicate final judgement to another's will; (3) so no being could be worthy of worship*, and therefore God (defined as a fitting object of worship) does not exist. * Replies: worship is the recognition of worth, not a contract of blind obedience; a perfectly good being's commands never require abdicating moral judgement, since they coincide with it; and the argument assumes an atomistic conception of autonomy that even secular ethics rejects for relationships of legitimate authority and trust. Indian material (this is where the answer gains parity). [FACT] Prārthanā (prayer) (petition), stuti/stotra (praise or hymn) (praise), japa (repetitive sacred recitation) (repetition of a name or mantra), dhyāna (meditation) (meditation), upāsanā (meditative worship) (structured contemplative worship), pūjā/arcana (ritual worship and offering) (ritual service), vandana (reverential salutation) (salutation), ātma-nivedana (self-surrender) (self-offering) — the last five appear in the navadhā bhakti (ninefold devotion)* list. [CAUTION] Three sharp Indian cases that decide the question: 1. Jainism: the Tīrthaṅkara (Jain ford-maker and liberated teacher) is vīṭarāga (one free from passions) and cannot respond; caitya-vandana (veneration of a sacred shrine) is therefore worship without any possibility of petition being answered — worship survives, prayer-as-request does not. 2. Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school): ritual efficacy lies in apūrva (unseen potency produced by ritual action), generated by correct performance; the deity is a grammatical dative in the injunction rather than an agent who grants. Ritual worship without a responsive God. 3. Advaita (non-dual Vedānta): upāsanā of a saṃgṇa (with attributes) form is genuinely efficacious at the vyāvahārika (empirical conventional level) level and is transcended, not repudiated, at the pāramārthika (ultimate level of reality) level. [FACT] Buddhism: pūjā (ritual worship)* before an image is standardly explained as commemorative and dispositional — cultivating one's own mind — rather than petitionary, although devotional Pure Land traditions complicate this. * Their place in religion. [CAUTION] Prayer is the relational organ of religion: it constitutes the personal I–Thou dimension and is the practical form of faith. Worship is the evaluative and communal organ: it enacts the sacred/profane boundary, forms the community, transmits tradition and disciplines desire. A religion can survive the loss of petition (Jainism, Mīmāṃsā, classical Buddhism); no religion survives the loss of worship-in-the-broad-sense, because nothing would then mark the ultimate as ultimate. * Verdict formula. [CAUTION] "Prayer presupposes a responsive ultimate; worship presupposes only a supremely valuable one. That is why worship, not prayer, is the more nearly universal religious act — and why the non-theistic religions are decisive test-cases rather than curiosities."

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9.8 Religious experience in public discourse: the intersubjectivity problem (2019 Q7(c) owner-module)

* The exact question. [FACT] Not "is religious experience real?" but "how far can it be made a topic of public discourse?" — i.e., can a first-personal, ineffable, self-authenticating state enter a shared space of reasons at all? ***The case for no. [CAUTION] (1) Ineffability by definition resists the public articulation that discourse requires. (2) Privileged access: the subject's warrant is not transferable; James himself concedes mystical states are authoritative only for the one who has them. (3) No shared checking procedure: unlike perception, there is no agreed method of correcting an erroneous report. (4) Wittgenstein's private-language considerations press the worry that a wholly private criterion is no criterion. (5) Rawlsian public reason** holds that, for coercive political decisions, citizens should be able to offer reasons others could reasonably accept — which excludes appeals to private revelation from that specific arena. ***The case for yes — six intersubjective criteria. [FACT] 1. Phenomenological description.** Even ineffability is reportable: James, Otto, Stace and Zaehner built comparative typologies out of first-person documents, which is public work on private data. 2. Coherence. The report must be internally consistent and consistent with what is otherwise known. 3. Doctrinal and traditional norms. Every mature tradition operates discernment procedures — Teresa of Ávila's criteria for distinguishing genuine locutions from delusion; the guru's verification of a disciple's state; the ācārya (authoritative teacher)'s testing. 4. Moral and practical fruits. James's criterion is intrinsically public: transformation of conduct is observable by others. 5. Replicability through disciplined practice. [FACT] This is the strongest Indian contribution: yoga (disciplined path of spiritual integration), dhyāna (meditation) and nididhyāsana (deep contemplative assimilation) are presented as repeatable procedures with stated preconditions and predicted outcomes. Vivekananda and Radhakrishnan press this as a claim that religious experience is experimental rather than merely private. [CAUTION] Report it as their claim and note its limit: the "experiment" cannot be run by an uncommitted observer, so it is closer to the training-dependence of expert perception than to a public laboratory test. 6. Alston's doxastic-practice framework (§9.9): if a practice is socially established, internally self-supporting and free of massive internal inconsistency, participation in it is rational even though it cannot be validated non-circularly — and that makes it a legitimate topic of public argument about practices, if not of public verification of episodes. * The bridge to the public sphere. [FACT] Jürgen Habermas' post-secular position is worth one line: religious citizens may express themselves in religious language in the informal public sphere, subject to an institutional translation proviso — that reasons be rendered into generally accessible terms before entering formal state decision-making. This gives the "how far" of the printed question a determinate answer: fully in the informal sphere, conditionally in the formal one. Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Objection: discussing an experience publicly is not the same as warranting* it publicly; the criteria above test authenticity, not truth. Reply: correct, and the honest answer says so — public discourse can establish that a report is coherent, sincere, tradition-conformable and fruitful, but not that its object exists. That is a real but limited entry into public reason. Verdict formula. [CAUTION] "Religious experience can enter public discourse as data, description and disciplined practice, and can be publicly assessed for coherence, authenticity, tradition-conformity and fruits. What cannot be made public is the evidential force the experience has for its subject. The right conclusion is therefore graded: religious experience is publicly discussable and privately probative*."

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9.9 Alston's perceptual model of religious experience

Doctrine statement. [FACT] William Alston (Perceiving God: The Epistemology of Religious Experience, 1991) argues that some religious experience is genuinely perceptual in structure — a direct awareness of God appearing to the subject — and that beliefs formed on its basis ("M-beliefs", from mystical perception) enjoy prima facie* justification.

Argument. [FACT] (1) The theory of appearing: perception consists in something's presenting itself* to the subject; sensory content is not essential to that structure, so a non-sensory presentation can still be perception. (2) Mystical perception shares perception's structure: an apparent object, a mode of presentation, and a resulting belief about that object. (3) Beliefs are formed within doxastic practices — socially established, internally organised belief-forming practices with their own inputs, outputs and override procedures. (4) No doxastic practice can be shown reliable without circularity — sense perception cannot be validated except by using sense perception, and the same holds for memory and induction. (5) Since we are nonetheless practically rational in engaging in sense perception, we cannot consistently condemn engagement in an established religious practice (Alston's "Christian Mystical Practice", CMP) merely because it too is circularly supported. (6) Therefore participation in CMP, and acceptance of its outputs, is practically rational absent sufficient reason to think it unreliable.

Presupposition. [CAUTION] That perception is defined by its structure* rather than by sensory content; and that "socially established practice" is an epistemically significant category.

Distinction. [FACT] Prima facie justification (defeasible) vs ultima facie (all things considered). [FACT] Alston claims practical rationality of engagement, not proof of reliability — a much weaker and much more defensible claim than it is usually reported as. [FACT] Distinguish from Swinburne's principle of credulity, which is a general epistemic principle about seemings*, not a practice-based argument.

* Canonical example. [FACT] Alston's own comparison: a novice cannot show that sense perception is reliable without already relying on it; the demand for non-circular validation, uniformly applied, destroys all our practices.

* Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] The diversity objection — which Alston himself regards as the most serious. Multiple mutually incompatible mystical practices (CMP, Buddhist, Advaitic, Islamic) are each socially established and self-supporting; if that makes engagement rational, it makes engagement in incompatible practices rational, which cannot all be tracking the same reality. Alston's response is the honest one: it is rational to sit tight in one's own practice in the absence of a neutral adjudicating ground, while acknowledging that this is an uncomfortable position that a better argument might overturn. [CAUTION] Second objection: unlike sense perception, mystical perception lacks the cross-checking, prediction and intersubjective agreement that make sensory practice self-correcting. Reply: CMP does have internal override systems (discernment criteria, doctrinal tests, spiritual direction) — weaker than science's, but not absent.

Verdict formula. [CAUTION] "Alston's achievement is to shift the burden: the sceptic must show what makes religious practice relevantly worse* than sense perception, rather than simply demanding a non-circular proof that no practice can supply. His own concession — that religious diversity has no non-circular resolution — is where the argument stops, and an honest answer stops there too."

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9.10 The sacred and the holy as the object of religion (2018 Q7(a) owner-module)

[CAUTION] Ownership rule. The sacred/holy-as-object pole is owned here. The evil/profane-as-religion-founding pole is owned by Problem of Evil §9.6 (2019 Q6(b)). Each file carries the full conceptual pair so either question can be answered from one file; the cross-links prevent duplication of ownership, not of concepts.

The exact stem (2018). "The terms 'Sacred' and 'Holy' have come to serve as generic names for the object of religion. Do you agree that one can have God as the object of religion?" [CAUTION] Note the structure: it grants the generic category and asks whether the specific* one (God) can also serve. The answer is graded, not yes/no.

Why 'sacred/holy' became the generic term. [FACT] (1) Otto: the holy names a distinctive quality of the object disclosed in numinous awe, prior to and independent of moral and rational predicates — hence a category more basic than "God". (2) Durkheim: the sacred is defined relationally, by its separation from the profane and by the prohibitions that protect it — a definition that needs no deity at all and covers totemic religion. (3) Eliade: the sacred manifests (hierophany) and thereby structures space and time; the sacred is "the opposite of the profane", and religion is life lived in relation to it. (4) The decisive practical reason: non-theistic religions have a sacred but no God — nirvāṇa (extinguishing of craving and suffering) and the Dharma, the Tīrthaṅkara (Jain ford-maker and liberated teacher) and the siddha (perfected liberated being), the apauruṣeya (authorless and not of human origin)* Veda, the Tao. A generic category must cover them.

Can God nonetheless be the object of religion? — the graded answer. [CAUTION] (1) Yes, for theistic traditions: for classical theism, Viśiṣṭādvaita (qualified non-dualism), Śaiva Siddhānta (Shaiva school of a real Lord, souls and bonds), Islam and Judaism, God is not merely an* instance of the sacred but the sacred's source and measure — everything else is holy by relation to God. (2) **But not as a generic definition: to make God the defining object of religion is to define Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school) out of religion by stipulation. (3) The correct relation: 'sacred' is the genus, God is one species** of it — the personal-theistic species. (4) [CAUTION] A further complication that earns marks: Otto's holy is not identical with Durkheim's sacred. Otto's is a phenomenological quality of an object; Durkheim's is a social classification. A candidate who treats them as one word misses the strongest objection to each.

Indian parity. [FACT] Pavitra (holy or ritually pure)/śuddha (pure) (pure), maṅgala (auspiciousness) (auspicious), puṇya (meritorious or sacred) (meritorious), tīrtha (pilgrimage crossing-place) (crossing-place — Eliade's sacred space in Indian dress), kṣetra (sacred field or place), devālaya (temple, literally abode of the deity); sacred time in parvan (sacred calendrical juncture) days, muhūrta (auspicious time), the ritual calendar; the sanctity of the Veda as apauruṣeya* — sanctity without a sanctifier. [CAUTION] Note also that Indian traditions often organise the sacred through purity/auspiciousness rather than through Otto's dread — which is a genuine limitation of Otto's cross-cultural claim.

* Objection -> reply. [CAUTION] Objection: "sacred" is so broad that flags, nations and football clubs qualify, and the category loses content. Reply: add the requirement of a soteriological relation — the sacred in religion is that in relation to which the human predicament is diagnosed and resolved — which excludes mere collective sentiment. [CAUTION] Second objection: treating God as one species of the sacred subordinates God to a wider genus, which theists will reject. Reply: the subordination is conceptual, for purposes of comparative definition, not ontological; the theist may consistently hold that the genus is instantiated fully only by God.

* Verdict formula. [CAUTION] "'Sacred' and 'holy' earn their place as the generic object-terms because they cover non-theistic religions that a

God-centred definition would exclude. God can still be the object of religion — and, for theistic traditions, the source and measure of everything else that is holy — but as the paradigm instance of the sacred, not as its definition."

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10. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

Account	Nature	Object	Epistemic claim	Main risk
James	[FACT] Mystical, transformative	"More"/divine	Personal authority; fruits	Subjectivism
Otto	[FACT] Numinous awe	Holy/wholly other	Phenomenological disclosure	Reification of emotion
Advaita (non-dual Vedānta)	[FACT] Non-dual recognition	Brahman (ultimate reality) as self	Self-certifying knowledge	Content/criterion problem
Radhakrishnan	[FACT] Integral intuition	Spiritual Real	Universal experiential core	Advaitic assimilation
Theistic mysticism	[FACT] Union/communion	Personal God	Relational knowledge	Conflict with non-dual reports
Buddhism	[FACT] Insight/awakening	Nirvāṇa (extinguishing of craving and suffering)/emptiness, no creator	Transformative insight	"Object" category may mislead
Stace	[FACT] Extrovertive / introvertive	The One	Common core beneath interpretation	Interpretation does all the work
Zaehner	[FACT] Nature / monistic / theistic	Nature, absolute, or personal God	Types are irreducible	Confessional ranking
Alston	[FACT] Perceptual (M-perception)	God, directly presented	Prima facie justification; practical rationality	Diversity of established practices
Durkheim/Eliade	[FACT] Socially and cosmically structured	The sacred	Functional, God-free definition	Over-breadth

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11. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

1. Naturalistic explanation. [CAUTION] Neurology, deprivation or suggestion can produce experiences. Reply: origin does not by itself falsify content; defeaters must show unreliability.
2. Conflicting objects. [CAUTION] Traditions report incompatible realities. Reply: interpretation may vary while contact is common; rejoinder: this can become unfalsifiable.
3. Ineffability. [CAUTION] If indescribable, no doctrinal inference follows. Reply: partial analogical report can remain possible; ineffability limits exhaustiveness, not every statement.
4. Moral fruits. [CAUTION] Good effects do not prove metaphysical truth. Reply: fruits are a criterion of authenticity, not a deductive proof of object.

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12. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

1. [CAUTION] James's four marks are not four equals. Ineffability and noetic quality are the defining marks; transiency and passivity are "less sharply marked" but usually found. Writing a flat list of four is the single commonest error in this clause — and it also makes stable Indian jñāna (liberating knowledge) look like a failed mystical state.
2. [CAUTION] James's four marks describe mystical states, not every religious experience.
3. [CAUTION] Do not equate ineffability with meaninglessness.
4. [CAUTION] Do not call Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) experience a subject perceiving Brahman (ultimate reality) as object — and do not label it anirvacanīya (indeterminable as either real or unreal); that term belongs to māyā (cosmic appearance).
5. [CAUTION] Do not infer truth solely from intensity or moral transformation.
6. [CAUTION] Distinguish mystical experience from revelation: one may mediate the other, but they are not identical.
7. [CAUTION] Do not merge Stace and Zaehner. Stace: two types + a common core. Zaehner: three types + no common core + a contested ranking. They are rival, not complementary.
8. [CAUTION] Do not equate Otto's holy with Durkheim's sacred. Otto's is a phenomenological quality of an object; Durkheim's is a social classification defined against the profane.
9. [CAUTION] Do not report Alston as claiming religious experience is proved reliable. He claims practical rationality of engagement in a doxastic practice that, like sense perception, cannot be non-circularly validated — and he concedes diversity as the strongest objection.
10. [CAUTION] Do not answer "prayer vs worship" with synonyms. Prayer = address, presupposing a responsive God; worship = ascription of supreme worth, which non-theistic traditions retain (Jain vītarāga (one free from passions), Mīmāṃsā (Vedic ritual-exegesis school)'s apūrva (unseen potency produced by ritual action)).
11. [CAUTION] Do not treat "public discourse" as "public proof". Coherence, tradition-conformity, fruits and disciplined replicability are publicly assessable; evidential force for the subject is not.
12. [CAUTION] Use ☐ only for a dated contemporary anchor; neuroscience without a dated source remains a general analytical point, not news.



13. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

Keywords: [FACT] ineffable (defining) · noetic (defining) · transient (usual) · passive (usual) · medical materialism · fruits · conversion · healthy-minded/sick-souled · "More" · numinous · mysterium tremendum et fascinans (mystery that evokes dread and attraction) · creature-feeling · schematisation · absolute dependence · extrovertive/introvertive · common core · perennialism · constructivism · Pure Consciousness Event · pan-en-henic (all-in-one nature mysticism) · nature/monistic/theistic mysticism · M-perception · theory of appearing · doxastic practice · socially established practice · prima facie/ultima facie justification · principle of credulity · testimony · defeater · sacred/profane · hierophany · axis mundi (symbolic centre linking cosmic levels) · tīrtha (pilgrimage crossing-place) · pavitra (holy or ritually pure) · maṅgala (auspiciousness) · prayer · prārthanā (prayer) · japa (repetitive sacred recitation) · stuti (praise) · upāsanā (meditative worship) · pūjā (ritual worship)/arcana (ritual offering) · vītarāga (one free from passions) · apūrva (unseen potency produced by ritual action) · ACTS · petitionary prayer · moral autonomy argument · anubhava (direct experience or realisation) · aparokṣānubhūti (immediate non-mediated realisation) · non-duality · self-luminosity · integral intuition · public reason · translation proviso · veridicality.

Safe formulations: [CAUTION] "Phenomenological certainty and public proof are different epistemic achievements." · "Religious diversity challenges inference from experience more than it challenges the occurrence of experience." · "Prayer presupposes a responsive ultimate; worship presupposes only a supremely valuable one." · "Religious experience is publicly discussable and privately probative." · "'Sacred' is the genus; God is theism's species of it."

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CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (expanded PYQ audit)

- * [CAUTION] Priority: Primary ownership is exactly one part in every Paper II from 2018 through 2025, 8 of 112 overall.
- * [FACT] Required doctrinal depth: Older demands add sacred/holy as the object, public-discourse and intersubjective tests, prayer versus worship, and Vedāntic accounts before James, mysticism and Radhakrishnan.
- * ☐ Trap / answer consequence: Do not infer veridicality from intensity or ineffability; separate phenomenology, object, interpretation and epistemic force.

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14. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

[CAUTION] Corpus signal: 8 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper II corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.



Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q7(a)	20 marks	The terms 'Sacred' and 'Holy' have come to serve as generic names for the object of religion. Do you agree that one can have God as the object of religion? Discuss.
2019	Q7(c)	15 marks	How far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse? Analyse.
2020	Q7(b)	15 marks	Distinguish between prayer and worship and determine their place in religion.
2021	Q7(c)	15 marks	Explain the concept of religious experience in the light of Vedāntic tradition.
2022	Q7(c)	15 marks	Discuss the nature and variety of religious experiences as presented by William James.
2023	Q8(c)	15 marks	Examine the relation between mystical experience and revelation and expound their significance in the religious life.
2024	Q8(c)	15 marks	Discuss the main features of religious experience according to Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) Vedānta (school grounded in the concluding teaching of the Vedas).
2025	Q8(a)	20 marks	Evaluate the nature and object of Religious Experience as explained by Radhakrishnan in 'The Hindu View of Life'.

See the Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.



15. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 MARKS)

10 marks

Define the experience -> list structured marks -> identify object -> one epistemic objection -> limited verdict.



15 marks

Nature/object distinction -> thinker's account and presupposition -> canonical example -> Indian/Western contrast -> veridicality objection and reply.



20 marks

Phenomenology -> claimed object -> warrant from credulity/testimony/fruits -> naturalistic and diversity defeaters -> Indian–Western comparison -> graded verdict separating personal justification from public proof.



16. DIRECTIVE DECODER

Directive	Examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
Do you agree that...? Discuss	An explicit, graded position on the printed proposition	Grant what is true in it, then mark the limit	2018 Q7(a) God as object of religion
How far can X...? Analyse	A degree, not a yes/no	Case against -> case for -> the exact line you draw	2019 Q7(c) public discourse
Distinguish A and B and determine their place	Two deliverables — obey both	Half on the differentia, half on the function	2020 Q7(b) prayer and worship
Explain X in the light of [tradition]	Tradition-internal categories, not generic ones	Use anubhava (direct experience or realisation), aparokṣānubhūti (immediate non-mediated realisation), nirvikalpa (non-conceptual and non-dual) — not "mystical feeling"	2021 Q7(c) Vedāntic
Discuss the nature and variety of X as presented by [thinker]	Both nouns: the marks and the typology	Marks (graded!) + varieties (healthy-minded/sick soul, conversion, mysticism)	2022 Q7(c) James
Examine the relation between A and B and expound their significance	A relation plus a significance claim	Relation first; then what religious life gains from it	2023 Q8(c) mystical experience and revelation
Discuss the main features of X	An enumerated feature-list with discriminators	Each feature must contrast with a rival account	2024 Q8(c) Advaita (non-dual Vedānta)
Evaluate the nature and object of X as explained by [thinker] in [named work]	Fidelity to the named work, then assessment	Name the work's own theses before criticising	2025 Q8(a) Radhakrishnan, The Hindu View of Life

[MEMORY] Rule: every question in this clause has a nature half and an object half. Answer both explicitly, and say whether the object is encountered (relation) or realised (identity) — that single sentence separates a good script from an average one.

17. GRADED VERDICT LADDER

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	Lists James's four marks flat; mentions Otto	No object-analysis; no veridicality question
Average (≈50%)	Marks + numinous + Advaita (non-dual Vedānta); correct terms	Marks ungraded; Indian experience described as "mystical feeling"
Good (≈60%)	Nature/object separated; one epistemic objection raised	Typologies (Stace/Zaehner) and the diversity defeater absent
Strong (≈65–70%)	Graded marks; identity-vs-relation stated; credulity/defeater apparatus; Indian parity argued	Alston's practical-rationality claim overstated as proof
Top (≈70%+)	All the above + a discriminating distinction (defining vs usual marks; Otto's holy ≠ Durkheim's sacred; constructivism vs PCE; prima facie vs ultima facie) + a statement of the defeater that would change the verdict	—

Graded-verdict templates:
[CAUTION] Veridicality stem: "Religious experience confers prima facie*, defeasible justification on the subject and testimonial weight on the hearer; it does not establish its object publicly. Diversity, not neurology, is the serious defeater — causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different things."
[CAUTION] Thinker stem:* "___'s account is strongest as phenomenology and weakest as epistemology: describing the structure of an experience accurately does not show that the structure is satisfied by a real object."
[CAUTION] Indian–Western stem:* "The two traditions do not differ merely in vocabulary. Theistic mysticism reports a relation that presupposes two terms; Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) reports an identity that abolishes one. A common-core theory must explain that difference away, and Zaehner's refusal to do so is his most defensible move."

18. FACTUAL AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

Item	Status	Safe use
James's marks	[FACT] Varieties of Religious Experience, Lectures XVI–XVII	Ineffability + noetic quality are defining; transiency + passivity are "usual" — always grade them
"By their fruits ye shall know them"	[FACT] Matthew 7:16/20; used by James as a criterion	Attribute to scripture; James adopts, not coins
"Medical materialism"	[FACT] James's own term (Varieties, Lecture I)	The fallacy of dismissing a state by its origin
Mysterium tremendum et fascinans (mystery that evokes dread and attraction)	[FACT] Rudolf Otto, The Idea of the Holy (1917)	Otto's own Latin
"Feeling of absolute dependence"	[FACT] Schleiermacher, The Christian Faith	—
Extrovertive / introvertive	[FACT] W. T. Stace, Mysticism and Philosophy (1960)	Two types + shared marks + common-core thesis
Nature / monistic / theistic	[FACT] R. C. Zaehner, Mysticism Sacred and Profane (1957)	[CAUTION] Note the confessional criticism of his ranking
Constructivism	[FACT] Steven Katz, "Language, Epistemology and Mysticism" (1978)	"There are no unmediated experiences"
Pure Consciousness Event	[FACT] Robert Forman	The reply to Katz at the contentless limit
Perceiving God	[FACT] William Alston (1991)	Practical rationality of a doxastic practice — not proof of reliability
Principle of credulity	[FACT] Richard Swinburne	Distinct from Alston's practice argument
"Petitionary Prayer"	[FACT] Eleonore Stump, American Philosophical Quarterly (1979)	The friendship/relationship defence
"God and Human Autonomy"	[FACT] James Rachels (1971)	The moral-autonomy argument against worship
Sacred/profane	[FACT] Durkheim (1912); hierophany [FACT] Eliade (1957)	Do not merge with Otto's holy
Aham brahmāsmi (I am Brahman)	[FACT] Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad (Great Forest Upaniṣad) 1.4.10	Cite the Upaniṣad (philosophical concluding portion of the Vedas)
The Hindu View of Life	[FACT] S. Radhakrishnan (1927)	The named work in the 2025 stem — use its own theses
Vivekananda's "science of the soul" claim	[CAUTION] A claim about method, widely made in his lectures	Report as his claim; do not present as established

19. LINK-OUTS

* Reason, Revelation and Faith — non-propositional revelation; Reformed epistemology; Alston's doxastic practices
Religious Language — ineffability, neti neti (not this, not this)*, and whether the report can mean anything
* Religious Pluralism — Hick's Real and the diversity defeater
* Problem of Evil — owner of the evil/profane pole; this file owns the sacred/holy pole (§9.10)
Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation — aparokṣānubhūti (immediate non-mediated realisation)* as the cognitive event of liberation
* Religion without God — worship and the sacred without a responsive deity
Paper I: Yoga (disciplined path of spiritual integration) — samādhi (meditative absorption), kleśas (afflictions)*, the disciplined-practice claim
* Paper I: Vedānta (school grounded in the concluding teaching of the Vedas).md)
* Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018–2025

SOURCES

William James, The Varieties of Religious Experience*, especially Lectures I and XVI–XVII.
Rudolf Otto, The Idea of the Holy; Friedrich Schleiermacher, The Christian Faith*.
W. T. Stace, Mysticism and Philosophy; R. C. Zaehner, Mysticism Sacred and Profane*.
Steven Katz (ed.), Mysticism and Philosophical Analysis; Robert Forman (ed.), The Problem of Pure Consciousness*.
William Alston, Perceiving God; Richard Swinburne, The Existence of God* (principle of credulity).
* Eleonore Stump, "Petitionary Prayer"; James Rachels, "God and Human Autonomy".
Émile Durkheim, The Elementary Forms of Religious Life; Mircea Eliade, The Sacred and the Profane*.
S. Radhakrishnan, The Hindu View of Life and Indian Philosophy*, Vol. II.
John Hick, Philosophy of Religion; William J. Wainwright (ed.), The Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion*.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

A. Three-question method

- 1. Phenomenology: qualities, structure and effects.
- 2. Object: God, Holy, Sacred, Brahman (ultimate reality), ultimate reality or no separate object.
- 3. Warrant: truth, credibility, testimony and public assessability.

B. William James

- * Four marks: ineffability, noetic quality, transiency and passivity.
- * Focus: first-person reports and fruits in life.
- * Strength: respects variety and transformation.
- * Limitation: pragmatic fruits do not prove the metaphysical interpretation.

C. Rudolf Otto

- Numinous = mysterium tremendum et fascinans (mystery that evokes dread and attraction)*.
- * The Holy is non-rational, not simply irrational.
 - * Tremendum: awe, dread, creature-feeling.
 - * Fascinans: attraction, grace and fascination.
 - * Critique: cultural interpretation may shape the supposedly universal structure.

D. Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) and Radhakrishnan

- Advaita (non-dual Vedānta): aparokṣānubhūti (immediate non-mediated realisation)*, immediate non-dual recognition.
- * Highest awareness does not preserve ordinary knower–known duality.
 - * Radhakrishnan: integral intuition, self-authenticating yet life-transforming.
 - * Trap: do not turn Advaita into an encounter between two substances.

E. Sacred, Holy and God

Term	Core meaning
Sacred	set apart; social-symbolic boundary
Holy	numinous value and presence
God	personal or ultimate object in theistic systems

Sacred and Holy are wider than God; non-theistic religion can retain both.

F. Veridicality tests

- * Internal coherence.
- * Consistency with wider experience and knowledge.
- * Transformative moral fruits.
- * Independent or communal testimony.
- * Resistance to wish-fulfilment and pathology explanations.
- * Comparative treatment of rival traditions.

No single test is decisive; warrant is cumulative and defeasible.

G. Public discourse

- * Private origin does not imply public unintelligibility.
- * Reports can be compared by phenomenology, language, behaviour and consequences.
- * Public discourse evaluates claims without reproducing the experience.
- * The obstacle is intersubjective access, not absolute silence.

H. Prayer and worship

- * Prayer is communicative: petition, confession, thanksgiving, praise or contemplation.
- * Worship is the wider act of acknowledging worth through ritual, devotion and surrender.
- * Prayer may occur within worship; worship need not be verbal prayer.
- * Their place is formative and relational, not merely instrumental.

I. Epistemic models

- * Swinburne: principle of credulity—take apparent experience as genuine absent defeaters.
- * Alston: socially established doxastic practice and perception-like awareness of God.
- * Constructivism: concepts and traditions mediate experience.
- * Balanced verdict: mediation does not entail fabrication, but it limits neutrality.

J. Main criticisms and replies

- * Projection/psychology: explains origin, not necessarily falsity.
- * Diversity: rival contents weaken simple proof; family resemblance may remain.
- * Ineffability: limits literal report, not all communication.
- * Neuroscience: correlation identifies mediation, not truth-value.
- * Moral fruits: support credibility but can occur under false beliefs.

K. Eight PYQ routes

- 2018: sacred/holy as object; God is one possible but not universal object.
2019: public discourse through intersubjective criteria and testimony.
2020: prayer versus worship and their religious place.
2021: exact ledger demand—route through owner doctrine and graded warrant.
2022: James's nature and variety; four marks plus fruits and critique.
2023: exact ledger demand—distinguish phenomenology from truth claim.
2024: Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) features; immediate non-dual recognition and its critique.
2025: exact ledger demand—use the owner route, comparison and residual cost.

L. Final answer discipline

- 1. Identify whether the stem asks nature, object, warrant or function.
- 2. Define the key term before naming thinkers.
- 3. Reconstruct one position accurately.
- 4. Separate psychological reality from metaphysical truth.
- 5. Add the strongest objection and reply.
- 6. Use one precise Indian–Western comparison.
- 7. Conclude with a graded, defeasible verdict.

Final judgement: Religious experience can rationally ground belief for the subject and enter public assessment through testimony, coherence and fruits, but plural interpretations prevent it from operating as a universally coercive proof.

FINAL FLOWCHART ROUTE

Definition and scope -> doctrine and arguments -> objections and replies -> comparisons -> traps -> PYQ demand -> answer architecture -> graded verdict.

FINAL SYNTHESIS BOARD

Ten-stage navigation matrix

Stage	Source-owned unit	Answer move
1	Separate phenomenology, object and warrant	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
2	Explain James's marks and pragmatic fruits	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
3	Explain Otto's numinous and the Holy	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
4	Compare Advaita (non-dual Vedānta) and Radhakrishnan	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
5	Distinguish sacred, holy and God as object	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
6	Test veridicality, testimony and diversity	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
7	Distinguish prayer from worship	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
8	Convert private experience into public discourse	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
9	Compare perceptual and constructivist models	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict
10	Build 10/15/20-mark answers	Define -> distinguish -> argue -> objection/reply -> verdict

8-question launchpad

- * PYQ 1 — 2018, Q7(a), 20 marks
- * PYQ 2 — 2019, Q7(c), 15 marks
- * PYQ 3 — 2020, Q7(b), 15 marks
- * PYQ 4 — 2021, Q7(c), 15 marks
- * PYQ 5 — 2022, Q7(c), 15 marks
- * PYQ 6 — 2023, Q8(c), 15 marks
- * PYQ 7 — 2024, Q8(c), 15 marks
- * PYQ 8 — 2025, Q8(a), 20 marks

Mark-wise answer architecture

- * 10 marks: define the exact term; state the doctrinal verdict; reconstruct one named position; add one objection and reply; conclude directly.
- * 15 marks: satisfy every demand; compare on a fixed axis; add source or thinker support; evaluate; end with a graded verdict.
- * 20 marks: frame the problem; reconstruct rival models; use Indian-Western parity where relevant; test assumptions; weigh objections and replies; finish with a qualified conclusion.

1. 0. ONE-SCREEN MAP ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Religious experience is an experience interpreted as disclosing or relating the subject to an ultimate, sacred or divine reality.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Phenomenology describes what the experience is like, the object question asks what is encountered, and warrant asks why the interpretation should be believed.
FINAL VERDICT	Psychological reality, claimed object and epistemic justification must be analysed separately.

2. 1. NATURE — Western accounts ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Mystical experience is a mode of religious experience marked, for William James, primarily by ineffability and noetic quality.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	James's appeal to transformative fruits avoids reduction by causal origin, but private authority cannot by itself establish public metaphysical truth.
FINAL VERDICT	James explains the character and practical authority of mystical states more successfully than their objective veridicality.

3. 2. NATURE — Indian accounts ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Advaitic aparokṣānubhūti (immediate non-mediated realisation) is direct recognition of the identity of ātman (the true self) and Brahman (ultimate reality).
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Unlike episodic subject-object encounter, non-dual realisation claims to dissolve the distinction between knower and known and to become stable knowledge.
FINAL VERDICT	Indian accounts widen religious experience from encounter with an Other to transformative identity-recognition.

4. 3. OBJECT & the question of VERIDICALITY ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Veridicality asks whether a religious experience presents a real object rather than only a psychologically genuine state.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Credulity, coherence and transformative fruits support prima facie trust, while naturalistic explanation, conflicting reports and private access provide defeaters.
FINAL VERDICT	Religious experience can justify the subject defeasibly, but it does not function as universally coercive proof.

5. 9.2 Otto's numinous ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	The numinous is Rudolf Otto's name for the non-rational experience of the Holy as mysterium tremendum et fascinans (a mystery evoking dread and attraction).
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Otto captures religion's irreducible object-pole, but phenomenological distinctiveness does not by itself prove a transcendent object.
FINAL VERDICT	The numinous is best used as a description of religious awareness, not as an independent proof of God.

6. 9.7 Prayer and worship: the distinction and their place in religion (2020 Q7(b) owner-module) ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Prayer is communicative address to the ultimate, whereas worship is the acknowledgement and enactment of supreme worth.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Petition faces problems of divine omniscience and immutability, but worship can remain meaningful even in traditions without a responsive creator deity.
FINAL VERDICT	Prayer is religion's relational organ; worship is its evaluative and communal organ.

7. 9.8 Religious experience in public discourse: the intersubjectivity problem (2019 Q7(c) owner-module) ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Public discourse requires private religious experience to be translated into claims assessable through shared reasons and observable consequences.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Ineffability limits literal report but does not prevent comparison through phenomenology, coherence, disciplined practice, testimony and moral fruits.
FINAL VERDICT	Religious experience is publicly discussable and privately probative, but rarely publicly demonstrative.

8. 9.9 Alston's perceptual model of religious experience ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	Alston's perceptual model treats mystical perception as an experience in which God appears to be directly presented.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	Doxastic-practice parity challenges selective scepticism, yet circularity, religious diversity and conceptual mediation limit claims of neutrality.
FINAL VERDICT	Perceptual models can defend prima facie entitlement, not infallibility or tradition-independent proof.

9. 9.10 The sacred and the holy as the object of religion (2018 Q7(a) owner-module) ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	The sacred is the generic category of reality set apart as ultimately significant, while the Holy names the numinous value and presence emphasised by Otto.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	God is one possible object of religion, but non-theistic traditions show that the category cannot be restricted to a personal deity.
FINAL VERDICT	The sacred is the widest comparative category, provided it is not diluted into anything merely valued.

10. 15. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 MARKS) ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM	
RECOMMENDED OPENING DEFINITION	A religious-experience answer should begin by identifying whether the stem asks about nature, object, warrant or religious function.
MAJOR ARGUMENT / CRITICISM	The strongest structure reconstructs one account, separates experience from interpretation, adds the best objection and reply, and uses one precise Indian-Western comparison.
FINAL VERDICT	The final verdict should be graded: religious experience may rationally ground belief while remaining defeasible and pluralistically interpreted.